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ORIGINAL ARTICLE

Understanding McCracken's Meaning Transfer Model (MTM) in celebrity and influencer perfume advertisements

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Abstract

This study examines the application of McCracken's Meaning Transfer Model (MTM) to celebrity and influencer perfume advertisements through a qualitative and interpretive approach. It investigates how cultural and symbolic meanings in advertising are conveyed and internalized by consumers. Although MTM has been applied in areas such as fashion and luxury goods, its potential in the perfume industry has not been systematically explored. Perfume advertising relies on sensory and symbolic communication, which makes it a theoretically significant setting for studying how cultural meanings are constructed and transferred. The study draws on 21 semi-structured interviews with participants from diverse international backgrounds. Interpretive content analysis shows how meanings move across three stages: from culturally constituted symbols to endorsers, from endorsers to products, and from products to consumers. This process is shaped by branding aesthetics, emotional narratives, and perceptions of endorser authenticity. Findings demonstrate that perfume advertising functions as a cultural carrier that influences consumer identity and aspiration. The study extends the application of MTM to perfume advertising as a sensory-driven product category and highlights how symbolic storytelling, endorser authenticity, and cultural alignment shape consumer identity and brand relationships.

Keywords Celebrity endorsement · Consumer identity · Meaning transfer model · Perfume advertising · Qualitative research

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1 Introduction

Fragrance advertising represents a marketing domain characterized by symbolic communication, identity construction, and cultural association, because beyond its utilitarian attributes, perfume consumption is tied to identity and emotional resonance. Studies indicate that fragrance use signals cleanliness, social status, and personality, positioning perfumes as symbolic carriers of social meaning (Lenochová et al., 2012; Janssens & De Pelsmacker, 2009).

Unlike utilitarian goods, which highlight functionality, perfumes are marketed through intangible associations with personality, lifestyle, and aspiration. Toncar and Fetscherin (2012) show that fragrance advertising relies on visual and metaphorical cues to construct these symbolic attributes, emphasizing emotions and attraction rather than functional qualities. By shaping symbolic associations, fragrance advertising helps brands achieve differentiation (Toncar & Fetscherin, 2012). More broadly, advertising has been shown to increase consumer awareness of product differentiation, a mechanism particularly important in highly competitive markets (Barroso & Llobet, 2012).

Perfumes therefore operate as cultural expressions that embed lifestyle cues, emotional meaning, and identity claims. Recent research confirms that younger consumers, particularly in the niche segment, perceive fragrances as extensions of self and symbolic ownership (Liu et al., 2025).

As the global perfume industry continues to grow, it becomes important to examine how symbolic meaning is constructed and communicated through advertising especially in campaigns that involve celebrity and influencer endorsements. Industry estimates the value of the global perfume market at USD 54.12 billion in 2023, with projections reaching USD 96.28 billion by 2033 (Precedence Research, 2024). A 2024 Statista survey reports that 20% of global consumers make purchases influenced by celebrity and influencer endorsements, with engagement particularly high among younger demographics, specifically 45% of Gen Z and 32% of Millennials. In this context, endorsements play a central role in shaping brand narratives by conveying cultural meaning and reinforcing consumer perceptions of identity, aspiration, and self-expression.

Although research on celebrity and influencer endorsements has examined credibility, attractiveness, and identification effects across fashion, sports, and luxury goods (Erdogan, 1999; Bergkvist & Zhou, 2016; Schouten et al., 2019), it has not sufficiently addressed categories where sensory absence forces advertisers to rely on symbolic storytelling and cultural cues. In perfume advertising, scent cannot be directly communicated, and meaning is constructed through metaphor, imagery, and identity signaling. Existing endorsement studies capture mechanisms of persuasion, but they overlook how symbolic and sensory appeals function together as cultural carriers. This creates a theoretical and empirical gap in understanding how endorsements operate in categories where identity and aspiration are embedded in advertising symbolism rather than product function.

This study responds to that gap by applying McCracken's (1989) Meaning Transfer Model (MTM) within the context of perfume advertising. MTM is well suited to analyze how cultural meanings move from endorsers to products and consum-

ers, but its application to sensory-driven and symbolically saturated categories remains underexplored. A qualitative and interpretive approach allows for capturing the detailed ways consumers interpret advertising narratives and integrate symbolic meanings into their identities (Goulding, 2005; Gummesson, 2005). Drawing on 21 semi-structured interviews, the research examines how consumers interpret symbolic associations in perfume advertisements and how these meanings shape their self-perception. This inquiry is guided by the following research question: How can the MTM be applied to celebrity and influencer perfume advertisements to understand consumer behaviour? By combining MTM with consumer interpretations of perfume advertisements, this study contributes theoretically by extending the model to a context where cultural meaning is especially central, and empirically by revealing how endorsements shape identity and aspiration.

2 Theoretical backgrounds

2.1 Meaning transfer model

The Meaning Transfer Model (MTM) (Fig. 1), developed by McCracken (1989), explains how cultural meanings are embedded in consumer goods through advertising and consumption. The model identifies three locations of meaning: the culturally constituted world, the consumer good, and the consumer. Meanings originate in society through symbols, ideals, and values. These meanings are then transferred through advertising, the fashion system, and consumption rituals. Products carry the cultural meanings that consumers later adopt as part of their identity.

The process unfolds in three stages. In the first stage, advertising and media encode cultural meanings into representations of products and endorsers. In the second stage, endorsers such as celebrities or influencers serve as carriers who transfer symbolic attributes such as attractiveness, credibility, or authenticity to the product. In the third stage, consumers appropriate the product and internalize its symbolic associations. They use these associations to construct or reinforce identity (Williams, 2017).

Celebrity endorsements exemplify this process, as celebrities introduce symbolic meanings that shape brand perception. Through advertising, these meanings are linked to products, enabling consumers to form connections with the brand (Parmar et al., 2020). As consumers associate celebrities with specific qualities, these attri-

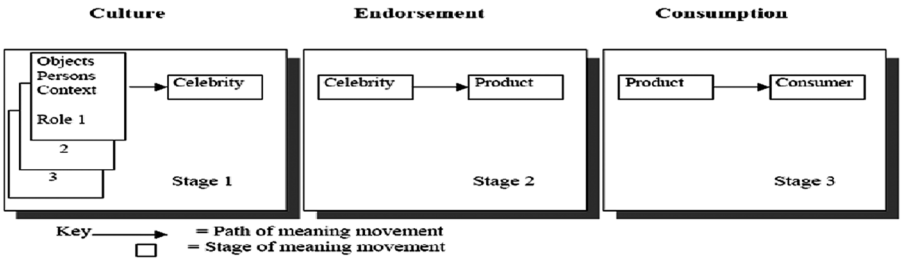


Fig. 1 Meaning Transfer Model. Source: McCracken, 1989, p.315

butes are transferred to the endorsed products, affecting consumer perceptions and purchase decisions (Choi et al., 2005).

2.2 Meaning transfer in perfume advertising

Perfume advertising plays a central role in the first stage of the Meaning Transfer Model, where cultural meanings are encoded into symbolic forms. Since scent cannot be transmitted directly, campaigns rely on visual, narrative, and auditory strategies that make fragrance understandable through culture and imagination.

One important strategy is **storytelling**, which transforms perfumes into emotional narratives. Campaigns often use themes such as love, passion, or adventure to create symbolic worlds for the viewer. Kang and colleagues (2020) describe this as storytelling advertising, which encourages audiences to see themselves as part of the story. Escalas (2004) found that narrative processing fosters emotional connection and strengthens consumer–brand relationships. Chanel's *Coco Mademoiselle* campaign from 2007, illustrates this technique by combining cinematic visuals and seductive scenarios to encode ideals of elegance and desire.

In addition to storytelling, perfume advertising also draws on **myth and archetype**. Floch (2002) identifies common codes such as love, seduction, poetry, and rebellion. Zelman (1992) observed that U.S. perfume campaigns often drew on ideals of the American dream, including masculinity, wealth, romance, and sexual fulfillment. These myths provide culturally recognizable scripts that advertisers embed in their messaging.

Semiotics and design provide additional tools for encoding meaning. Bottle shapes, typography, and logos act as cultural codes that position perfumes as symbols of identity. Minimalist bottles with bold lettering may represent modernity and confidence, while ornate designs suggest nostalgia and luxury (Nikiforova et al., 2023). **Color symbolism** reinforces these meanings. Warm tones such as red or orange are associated with intensity and exoticism, while pastels like lavender or blue signify subtlety and refinement (Welpix, 2024).

Music and soundscapes deepen the symbolic encoding of advertising. Soundtracks are chosen to communicate mood and lifestyle. Dior Homme's 2020 campaign with Robert Pattinson used Leonard Cohen's *I Am Your Man* to project sophistication, while Paco Rabanne's *1 Million* (2009) employed energetic rhythms to suggest vitality and youthful ambition. Korsgaard (2013) notes that the integration of music and visuals strengthens emotional impact, making advertising a powerful vehicle of symbolic meaning.

In this way, perfume advertising encodes cultural values through narrative, design, and sound, which marks the starting point of the meaning transfer process. The next stages involve endorsers and consumers carrying these meanings forward.

2.3 Endorsements and consumer identity

The second stage of the Meaning Transfer Model is visible in the role of celebrity endorsements, where symbolic qualities associated with public figures are transferred to products. In perfume advertising, this process positions fragrances as lifestyle

choices rather than functional items. Celebrities carry attributes such as glamour, attractiveness, or credibility, which are then linked to the fragrance through advertising. This symbolic transfer strengthens the aspirational appeal of perfumes and supports their role in consumer identity formation (Miller & Allen, 2012).

In recent years, influencers have become an important extension of this process. Their communication style is more interactive and personal than traditional celebrity endorsements, which makes them appear authentic and relatable. Varsha and Subhadip (2016) note that this quality allows influencers to create stronger and more individualized connections with their audiences. By showing how perfumes fit into daily life, influencers demonstrate the product's relevance and enhance its symbolic appeal.

The cultural fit between endorsers and consumers is a central factor in meaning transfer. According to Balaban et al. (2022), deeper identification occurs when influencer values align with followers. In MTM terms, these values are carried by the endorser at stage 2 and then passed to the product, where they can later be appropriated by the consumer.

Several studies have examined the conditions that determine how effectively endorsers transfer meaning to products, with credibility and trustworthiness identified as decisive factors. Erdogan (1999) showed that credible endorsers strengthen brand loyalty and purchase intentions. This is particularly relevant for perfumes because decisions in this category often rest on emotional and identity-based motivations. Hussain et al. (2020) further emphasize that long-term relationships between influencers and their followers build the trust necessary for meaning transfer to occur. Cervera-Taulet et al. (2013) highlighted consumer perception as central to enduring brand relationships. Varsha and Subhadip (2016) examined celebrity endorsements and showed that trust, credibility, and relevance moderate the process. MTM also accounts for reverse transfer, where the symbolic value of a brand enhances the reputation of its endorser, as when lesser-known celebrities gain prestige through association with luxury products. Stage 2 clarifies how endorsers transfer symbolic qualities to products while stage 3 shifts attention to consumers, who interpret these meanings and use them in identity construction.

The third stage of the model occurs when consumers adopt perfumes as identity markers. Endorsers introduce symbolic associations, and consumers integrate these meanings into their self-expression, treating fragrances as cultural artifacts that embody social values and distinctions (Parmar et al., 2020; Choi et al., 2005). This internalization involves a process of decoding, where consumers interpret and personalize the cultural symbols embedded in advertising. Curasi et al. (1998) showed that individuals construct narratives around valued possessions to preserve self-identity, a process that also applies to fragrances. Aaker (1991) explains that positive brand perceptions simplify decision-making and foster emotional attachment, while McPheron (2021) shows that favorable impressions increase the likelihood of repeat purchases. Ou and Chuang (2023) add that consumers often observe the perfume choices of others to guide their own selections, illustrating how social cues influence the adoption of fragrances as expressions of identity.

Perfume advertising requires the use of cultural and sensory codes to translate fragrance into symbolic form, which makes MTM a fitting framework for analyzing

how these meanings are constructed and transferred. Advertising in this area encodes cultural meanings through storytelling, myth, design, color, and music. Endorsers then carry these associations to products, which consumers adopt as expressions of identity. Other approaches in advertising research, such as the Elaboration Likelihood Model (Petty & Cacioppo, 1986) and the Heuristic-Systematic Model (Chaiken, 1980), explain persuasion by focusing on how consumers process information through central or peripheral routes. Attitude-change frameworks such as the Source Credibility Model (Hovland & Weiss, 1951) emphasize expertise, trustworthiness, and attractiveness as determinants of persuasive impact. These models are valuable for measuring message effectiveness, but they do not capture how symbolic and cultural meanings move between society, endorsers, products, and consumers. The use of MTM makes it possible to see perfume advertising as a cultural process, showing how meanings circulate between culture, endorsers, products, and consumers. This perspective reveals how fragrances become markers of self-expression and cultural belonging.

3 Methodology

Adopting an exploratory approach, this study investigates how consumers interpret meaning transfer in perfume advertisements which is an area with limited existing research. This method is relevant for revealing patterns and insights into consumer perceptions and behaviors, allowing for a flexible and in-depth examination that structured methods might overlook. Such an approach is essential for addressing the study's objectives within the context of celebrity and influencer endorsements in perfume advertising. A qualitative method was chosen for this research, employing semi-structured interviews. These interviews were selected for their flexibility in exploring participants' perspectives while maintaining a degree of consistency across interviews (Kvale, 1996; Roulston, 2010).

Purposive sampling was employed to select participants who could provide varied insights into celebrity and influencer endorsements in perfume advertising. This approach ensured the inclusion of individuals from diverse professional backgrounds (e.g., business development, psychology, law, and marketing), capturing a range of perspectives on advertising and cultural meaning transfer. Table 1, provides detailed socio-demographic characteristics, including interview durations. Additionally, Zsolt Zolyomi, a renowned Hungarian perfumer, was interviewed to provide industry insights.

The age range of participants was 25 to 38 years. This segment was selected because previous studies and industry reports show that purchases influenced by celebrity and influencer endorsements are most prevalent among younger consumers, especially Gen Z and Millennials (Statista, 2024). These groups are highly engaged with social media and advertising content, making them central to understanding meaning transfer in perfume campaigns. Including participants within this range ensured theoretical relevance by focusing on demographics where endorsements are most influential in shaping identity and aspiration. It also provided empirical rel-

Table 1 Socio-demographic characteristics and interview durations

Participant ID	Age	Gender	Occupation	Nationality	Education Level	Experience with Perfumes	Interview Duration
R1M	25	Male	Business development	Germany	Bachelor's	Moderate	45 minutes
R2M	28	Male	Sports reporter	Kazakhstan	Master's	Moderate	40 minutes
R3M	30	Male	Entrepreneur	Turkey	Master's	Moderate	42 minutes
R4F	32	Female	Psychologist	Germany	Master's	High	55 minutes
R5M	30	Male	Art director	Turkey	Master's	Moderate	40 minutes
R6M	N/A	Male	Legal department manager	Hungary	PhD	High	45 minutes
R7M	32	Male	Marketing manager	Ecuador	Master's	Moderate	40 minutes
R8F	28	Female	Business development	Bulgaria	Bachelor's	High	50 minutes
R9M	27	Male	Photographer	Mexico	Bachelor's	Moderate	44 minutes
R10F	29	Female	Entrepreneur	Mexico	Master's	Moderate	40 minutes
R11F	26	Female	Physiotherapist	Portugal	Master's	Moderate	45 minutes
R12M	35	Male	Business intelligence officer	Ecuador	Master's	Moderate	48 minutes
R13M	30	Male	Accountant	Tunisia	Master's	Moderate	40 minutes
R14F	29	Female	Marketing manager	Russia	Master's	High	52 minutes
R15M	25	Male	Accountant	Azerbaijan	Master's	Moderate	43 minutes
R16M	N/A	Male	Perfumer	Hungary	Not provided	Professional	1 hour
R17M	29	Male	Accountant	Azerbaijan	Master's	High	45 minutes
R18M	27	Male	Accountant	Azerbaijan	Master's	Moderate	42 minutes
R19F	N/A	Female	Business analyst	Hungary	Master's	High	50 minutes
R20F	26	Female	Lawyer	Hungary	PhD	Moderate	40 minutes
R21F	28	Female	Contract manager	Jordan	Master's	High	45 minutes

evance, as participants were able to articulate how endorsements affect their perceptions and purchase decisions in the contemporary perfume market.

The sample size of 21 participants was determined based on the principle of data saturation, where recurring themes and insights consistently emerged during the later stages of data collection. Galvin (2015) highlights the importance of context in determining saturation, suggesting that it depends on factors such as the complexity of the research topic and the diversity of the sample, rather than adhering to rigid numerical guidelines. This approach ensured the inclusion of both broad thematic patterns and detailed individual perspectives. In this case, key themes such as sensory pleasure, emotional comfort, mood enhancement, and personal identity in relation to fragrance use were identified and reinforced across multiple participants, suggesting that further interviews would not yield additional insights.

The data were analysed using exploratory content analysis which is widely supported in marketing research for its ability to interpret written and verbal messages (Milliken, 2001; Gummesson, 2005; Neuendorf, 2002). Scholars also emphasize its proficiency in deriving concise, topic-specific categories (Cole, 1988; Cavanagh, 1997) and its applicability to both qualitative and quantitative research (Elo & Kyngäs, 2008). This method is suitable for addressing the research objectives, as it enables detailed exploration of meaning transfer, a key focus of this study.

Throughout the content analysis process, reflexivity was maintained via a reflective log to document assumptions, coding decisions, and interpretations, ensuring transparency and self-awareness. Triangulation was employed by cross-referencing data from participant narratives, emerging themes, and theoretical frameworks. These practices strengthened the validity of findings and ensured alignment with the study's objectives.

The methodology employed in this study involved a combination of written and verbal interviews. The question template was designed to capture both surface-level responses and deeper meanings behind participants' perfume choices and justifications. Follow-up questions were used whenever necessary to explore the interviewees' point of view further, namely asking for examples and details about the scent characteristics. The projective techniques were added to the interview questions. According to Morrison et al. (2002), projective techniques (PT) enable individuals to project their own or underlying views onto external entities or individuals. The duration of each interview varied between approximately 40 min and one hour, allowing ample time for participants to articulate their opinions and share their experiences. The interview guide is accessible in the Appendix section.

The research utilized ATLAS.ti version 23, a qualitative data analysis tool, to facilitate a systematic approach to coding and theme identification. This tool helped structure data and visually map connections among emerging topics, aligning the analysis with the study's aims. All interviews were carefully transcribed to ensure accurate capture of participants' responses. Transcripts were imported into ATLAS.ti, where they were coded using both deductive and inductive methods. Deductive coding was guided by themes derived from the Meaning Transfer Model (MTM), such as identity alignment and cultural symbolism, while inductive coding allowed for the emergence of new themes. This dual approach ensured that the analysis remained both focused and open to novel insights, directly addressing the research question. Visuals were created using the networks in ATLAS.ti to aid systematic analysis and identify key themes and patterns within the data (Friese, 2012).

4 Results

The following subsections detail the key findings of this study. To structure the findings, the analysis was guided by three stages of Meaning Transfer Model (MTM): (1) encoding of cultural meanings in advertising, (2) transfer of these meanings from endorsers to products, and (3) appropriation of meanings by consumers. Each stage is illustrated with representative participant quotes and is accompanied by interpretive commentary that links the empirical material to the theoretical process of meaning transfer. A summary of the main results, organized by key themes and accompanied by representative participant quotes, is provided in Table 2 at the end of this section.

Table 2 Summary of key themes and findings

Key Themes	Findings	Representative Quotes
Brand Awareness	Both male and female respondents frequently recalled major scent brands like Dior, Burberry, Armani, Prada, Chanel. Television ads, word of mouth, and personal experiences were the main contributors to brand recognition.	R10F: "Carolina Herrera, Armani, Calvin Klein or Chanel" R3M: "I would say Giorgio Armani, Tom Ford, Diesel and Jean-Paul Gaultier. R14F: "Diptyque, Lalique, Chanel, Guerlain, Dior, Armani, etc. come to my mind" R5M:Burberry (Classic, Hero), Dior Sauvage. Prada…Chanel No.5. Word of mouth, that's how I have seen it"
Reasons and feelings associated with wearing a perfume	Perfume is linked to personal well-being, mood enhancement, and social interactions. Female respondents emphasized sensory pleasure, while males highlighted self-image and social impact. Perfume use was also tied to cultural norms in some contexts.	R11F: "I wear perfume in order to feel better on my skin, for me and for the people who surround me." R3M: "I wear perfume for leaving an impressive mark…" R9M: "To have a more pleasant smell, in my country, it is basically a must."
Scent Preferences	Women preferred floral and fresh fragrances, while men favored woody, leathery and fersh scents.	R19F: "I lover powdery and fresh" R8F: "Floral and sweet are my favorite scents" R5M: "I prefer fresh and clean smells" R12M: "For business or winter: wood, leather, tobacco"
Sources of Information about Perfumes	Participants often learned about perfumes through personal testing, friends, and online resources such as reviews and social media. Store trials were crucial for the final selection.	R11F: "I like to go to the shops and try them. I also ask my friends when I like theirs." R14F: "On perfume shops websites (like https://noseparis.com), at the shops from consultants, on the websites with the reviews like www.fragantica.ru"
Celebrity Endorsements & Advertising	Celebrities and advertising (especially music and visuals) significantly impacted brand perceptions. However, while celebrities caught participants' attention, the scent itself was a decisive factor for purchase. Somre respondents were skeptical.	R11F: "I like Miss Dior ads due to the combination of the images and the music used." R17M: "When we see our favorite celebrity on the ad, it automatically catches our attention… However, to enter my world, the smell has to do the job." R4F: "People might believe that celebrities have access to everything and therefore surely wear the "best" fragrances. They appear perfect, and much of it is likely unattainable for most people. However, a fragrance can offer the opportunity to feel a bit more valuable and to smell asluxurious as the celebritys" R19F: "Not for me. Perfumes/colognes smell different on everyone. I might test it but will not buy it just because it is endorsed by a celebrity.

4.1 Stage 1: Encoding of cultural meanings in advertising

4.1.1 Brand awareness

Participants recognized prominent perfume brands including Dior, Chanel, Armani, and Axe, reflecting the strong influence of advertising and social exposure. Television advertisements were especially salient. R5M explained, "They come to my mind because of the exposure to those advertisements often." This response illustrates how recurrent audiovisual stimuli encode cultural meanings into consumer memory, aligning with Zaltman's (2003) argument that advertising builds subconscious associations. Similarly, R14F recalled Axe because of its "popular and fun TV advertisement." This underscores how advertising narratives embed symbolic qualities such as humor and youthfulness into brand identity, reinforcing Stage 1 processes of cultural encoding.

Beyond advertising, participants highlighted word of mouth and cultural circulation as mechanisms of brand meaning. Chanel No. 5 was frequently cited for its iconic status. R3M remarked, "Word of mouth, that's how I have seen it." This comment shows how social discourse contributes to the encoding of symbolic status in luxury perfumes, with iconic products circulating as cultural references independent of direct consumption.

Personal experiences also shaped how participants engaged with niche perfumes. R4F stated, "I think of niche fragrances because I no longer buy the majority of my perfumes from major drugstores," and identified Diana Vreeland Devastatingly Chic and Amouage Dia as favorites. This example highlights how individual consumer practices encode distinctiveness and authenticity into brand meaning, extending beyond mainstream advertising to experiential contexts.

4.1.2 Reasons and feelings associated with wearing perfume

The use of perfume was influenced by motivations ranging from self-expression to cultural expectations (Fig. 2). Female participants emphasized emotional solace and sensory enjoyment. R11F explained, "I wear perfume in order to feel better on my skin, for me and for the people who surround me." This points to cultural associa-

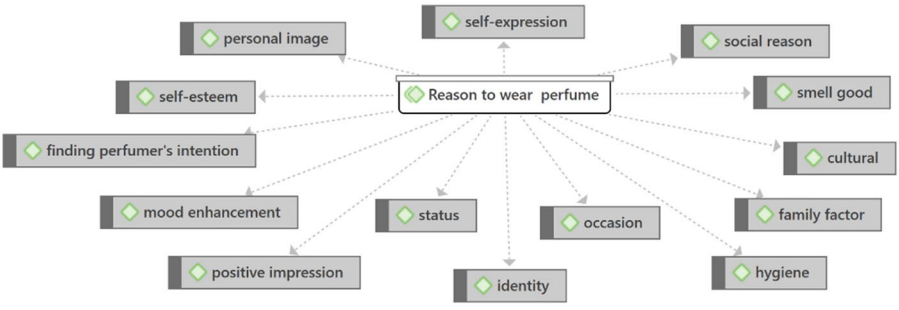


Fig. 2 Reason to wear perfume

tions of comfort and consideration for others that are often emphasized in branding narratives.

Male participants highlighted impression management. R3M stated, "I wear perfume for leaving an impressive mark on those whom I encounter." This shows cultural meanings of status and presence associated with fragrance. In Stage 1, these meanings are linked to perfume through symbolic cues and claims about character and effect. Perfume was also described as a cultural requirement in some contexts. R9M remarked, "To have a more pleasant smell, in my country, it is basically a must." This illustrates how social norms embed obligation into fragrance use, positioning it as part of appropriate public conduct rather than a matter of choice.

Figure 3 details the feelings that respondents associated with when wearing perfume. The frequency of those feelings was measured with the groundedness. According to ATLAS.ti user's manual (Groundedness – ATLAS.ti 23 Windows – User manual, 2023) this value indicates the number of quotations that are associated with a specific code. For both men and women, freshness (G13) and confidence (G12) were the main feeling that they experienced upon using a perfume of their choice. Attractiveness, cleanliness, were the next major feelings with groundedness values G7; G6 respectively. Masculinity (G4) and femininity (G3) had almost similar values. These codes indicate symbolic attributes that circulate culturally and that advertising links to perfume in Stage 1, which participants then repeat in their accounts.

4.1.3 Scent preferences

The study revealed diverse scent preferences among subjects, influenced by personal tastes and sensory experiences (Fig. 4). Female participants exhibited a wider range of preferences, with numerous individuals preferring floral and fresh scents. For

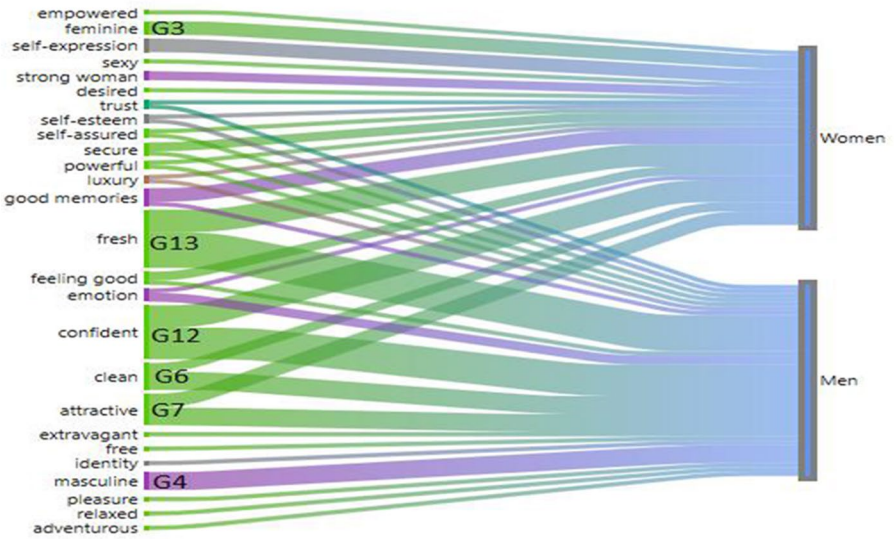


Fig. 3 Feelings associated with wearing perfume

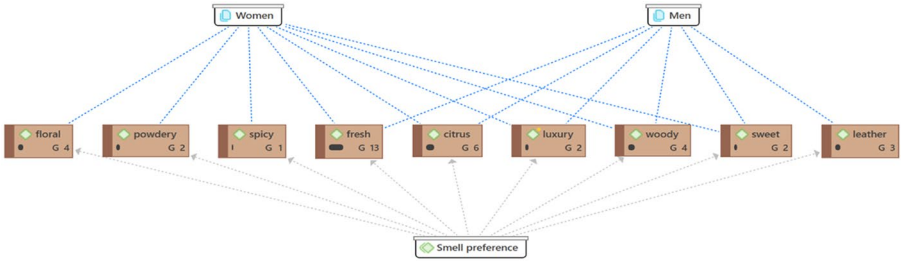


Fig. 4 Smell preference

example, R19F highlighted brands such as Gucci, Givenchy, and Guess. In contrast, male participants expressed a preference for woody and leathery notes, particularly for business or winter occasions, while opting for lighter, fresher scents for casual events or warmer weather. R7M mentioned brands like Giorgio Armani, Tom Ford, and Dior in this context.

Although these data indicate a gender-based disparity in smell preferences, such classifications may be shaped by cultural norms and marketing strategies rather than intrinsic variations in taste. Lindqvist (2012) asserts that the classification of fragrances into subgroups such as oriental floral or floral fruity gourmand for women and woody notes for men reflects longstanding market segmentation methods. These distinctions are frequently reinforced by advertisements and packaging that link particular smells to conventional gender roles. Interestingly, the citrus aromatic category is regarded as gender-neutral, as it includes scents intended for men, women, and unisex audiences. This highlights the possibility for evolving trends in the fragrance sector, where traditional gender boundaries are becoming blurred, facilitating a more inclusive perspective on smell preferences.

Taken together, these findings demonstrate how advertising, branding, and cultural norms encode symbolic meanings into perfumes. Brand recall, reasons for wearing fragrance, and scent preferences reveal how cultural ideals are embedded in advertising and product categories, preparing the ground for Stage 2 of the meaning transfer process, where endorsers act as carriers of these meanings and connect them to specific perfume brands.

4.2 Stage 2: Transfer from endorsers to products

Celebrity endorsements and advertising emerged as significant factors affecting participants' awareness and perceptions of fragrance products. Participants often emphasized the emotional power of visuals and music in commercials. R11F noted, "I like Miss Dior ads due to the combination of the images and the music used." This illustrates how advertising encodes symbolic meanings of elegance and emotional resonance, engaging subconscious processes that, according to Zaltman (2003), account for 95% of purchasing decisions rather than rational evaluation.

Participants highlighted the aspirational appeal of celebrity endorsements. R14F observed, "People always trust more people whom they recognize or want to be associated with." This finding aligns with Bandura's (1986) social learning theory, which

explains how individuals model their behaviors and preferences based on aspirational figures. Celebrity endorsements create symbolic connections that affect behavioral intentions, allowing customers to match their identities with those of admired public personalities.

Some participants, however, stressed that product qualities must ultimately validate celebrity associations. R17M stated, "When we see our favorite celebrity on the ad, it automatically catches our attention… However, to enter my world, the smell has to do the job." This shows a complex interaction between emotional appeal and practical evaluation, where the initial interest sparked by celebrity endorsements must finally be validated by the product's quality. Although celebrity endorsements increase brand awareness and elicit emotional responses, their impact on actual purchasing decisions is dependent on additional factors, namely sensory experience and individual taste.

Figure 5 depicts the interconnections between celebrity endorsements, buying decisions, and favorite advertisements, highlighting groundedness (G) and density (D) values. Density here (ATLAS.ti 23 Windows – User manual, 2023) shows the number of linkages of one code to other codes. Brand image and packaging, both integral components of perceived price, emerged as significant factors influencing buying decisions, operating alongside other determinants such as scent, longevity, credibility, and the aspirational lifestyle conveyed through celebrity endorsements. Research suggests that there are several aspects that influence consumers' purchasing decisions for a product, including size, design, content, color, and innovation. (Adam & Ali, 2014; Ansari & Siddiqui, 2019). The findings show that endorsements primarily influence brand awareness, but their impact on final purchase decisions is moderated by factors such as scent (G16) and credibility.

The emotional appeal of advertisements, often amplified by music and visuals, was also a key factor in shaping consumer buying-decision (D6). Leleń (2022) mentions that the incorporation of music and the interpretation of lyrics serve to enhance the emotional effect of the story and reinforce advertisement's message. Veres (2016) states that the buyers' choices are primarily influenced by the actual or perceived distinctions between goods, which also involve the specific conditions surrounding the purchase. However, customers have only little awareness of these preferences, which varies among individuals, situations, and products. Individuals are unaware that their underlying preferences influence their decisions in the same manner.

For the most part celebrity endorsement was associated with positive influence (G12) and brand image (G6). Only one negative influence was detected throughout the research. Both trust and celebrity image were the causes of credibility, and the latter eventually affected the purchase decision of the customer.

These results support the findings of Bergkvist and Zhou (2016) about the efficacy of celebrity and influencer endorsements in influencing brand perceptions and consumer purchase behaviors. However, as Djafarova and Rushworth (2017) argue, influencers often have a more pronounced impact on younger consumers, suggesting that traditional celebrity endorsements may hold varying levels of sway depending on the target demographic.

Above helps us to understand how endorsers transfer symbolic meanings to products, linking them with aspirational identities and lifestyles. However, their influence

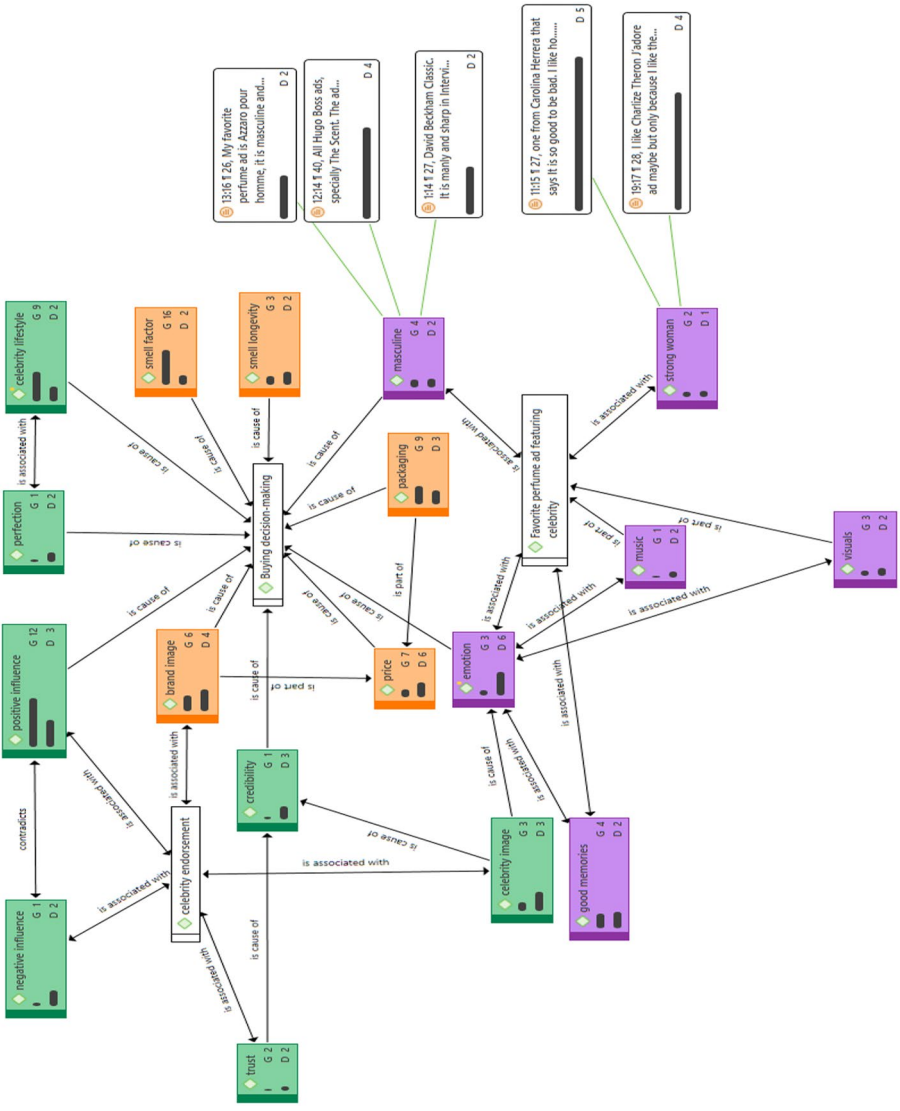


Fig. 5 Network linking buying decisions, celebrity endorsements, and perfume ads

on actual purchase decisions is moderated by sensory validation, product credibility, and brand attributes. This transition points to the third stage of the meaning transfer process, where consumers evaluate perfumes directly and incorporate symbolic meanings into their own identities.

4.3 Stage 3: Transfer from products to consumers

Participants relied on multiple information sources when selecting perfumes, reflecting a layered decision-making process (Fig. 6). In-store testing emerged as the pre-

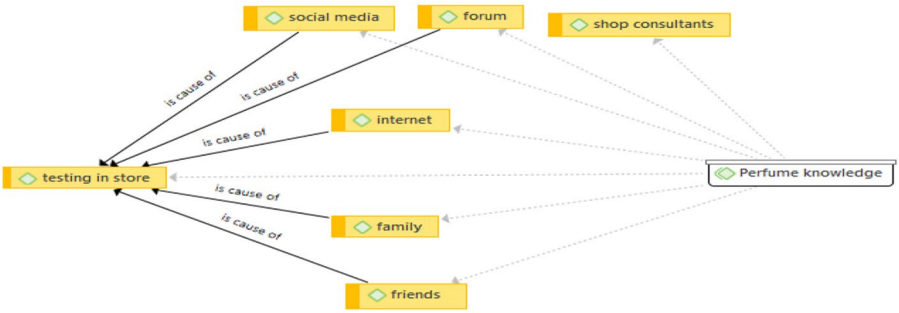


Fig. 6 Sources of information about perfumes

dominant method, emphasizing the importance of direct sensory experience. R11F explained, "I like to go to the shops and try them. I also ask my friends when I like theirs." This illustrates how symbolic meanings attached to perfumes are confirmed through embodied evaluation, while peer interactions provide additional validation and social reinforcement.

Interactions with friends and family significantly influenced participants' decisions. Digital platforms also shaped consumer decision-making by expanding exposure to symbolic narratives. R17M remarked, "Usually I check perfumes on Fragrantica when I hear about some unfamiliar perfume. I check the advertisements on YouTube, reviews, and all. Then I go to shop to smell it." This demonstrates how consumers integrate cultural meanings encountered in digital spaces with sensory confirmation, merging mediated narratives with personal experience.

The integration of internet research with in-store testing reflects a wider trend in customer behavior, wherein digital resources enhance conventional shopping experiences. These findings corroborate Chang and Wildt's (1994) argument that increased product knowledge bolsters purchasing confidence, as participants integrated personal experiences, peer insights, and web information to make informed decisions. Dependence on digital platforms signals a transformation in consumer interaction with scents, highlighting the necessity of multi-channel strategies for businesses seeking to connect with contemporary audiences.

Participants exhibited an integrated approach to perfume selection that included sensory, social, and digital inputs, shaped by both personal and external influences. This decision-making process demonstrates the interaction between sensory testing and cognitive assessment, reflecting the broader dynamics of consumer behavior shaped by cultural and technological contexts.

These findings demonstrate how consumers complete the meaning transfer process by connecting perfumes to their identities through trial, peer interaction, and digital engagement. In this stage, symbolic associations carried by endorsers and products are confirmed, personalized, and incorporated into consumer self-concepts, concluding the transfer of meaning from the culturally constituted world to the individual.

4.4 Summary of meaning transfer across the three stages

All three stages of the Meaning Transfer Model can be observed in sequence in these findings. In the first stage, advertising, cultural norms, and branding practices encode symbolic meanings into perfumes, shaping brand awareness, reasons for wearing fragrance, and scent preferences. In the second stage, celebrity endorsers act as carriers of these meanings, linking products with aspirational identities and emotional associations, while their influence remains moderated by credibility and product validation. In the third stage, consumers confirm and personalize these meanings through trial, peer interaction, and digital engagement, integrating them into their own identities. Together, the results show how cultural symbols embedded in advertising travel through endorsers and products before being anchored in consumer practice, completing the transfer of meaning.

5 Discussion

Analyzing the interview responses through McCracken's Meaning Transfer Model (MTM) provided a detailed understanding of the complex connection between perfume advertisements and consumer choices, revealing insights into the cultural and personal sources of meaning underlying perfume selection.

Participants' motivations for wearing perfume, such as making a positive impression and boosting confidence (Berliner, 1994; Hirsch, 2006), are deeply rooted in societal norms and individual identity construction, as outlined by MTM. They expressed how perfume provides a sense of security and enhances self-esteem, embodying cultural meanings related to self-assurance and personal presentation. For example, R4F highlighted how perfume contributes to her confidence in professional and social settings, reflecting cultural values associated with grooming and self-perception. Similarly, R11F also emphasized the role of perfume in improving her self-esteem and confidence, further illustrating the emotional and psychological significance of perfume use. This demonstrates how these personal experiences are tied to broader cultural ideals.

Fragrance qualities and branding were identified as crucial factors influencing participants' perfume selection, which aligns with the research of Borgave and Chaudhari (2010). Additionally, McCracken's Meaning Transfer Model (MTM) provides insights into both of these dimensions. Preferences for specific brands and unique scents reflect the role of products in transferring cultural meanings and matching with individual identity. For instance, R6M emphasized that choosing a fragrance that resonates with personal preferences enhances attractiveness and reinforces identity construction. Perfume, therefore, functions as a symbolic extension of one's personality, culture, and social status, shaping both self-perception and how others perceive the wearer (Boswell, 2008).

Packaging and branding also play significant roles in transferring meaning and attracting initial attention. Participants often associated adequate packaging with quality and desirability. R2M highlighted the extravagant and eye-catching packaging of Paco Rabanne's One Million, demonstrating how advertising shapes brand

image and packaging design to appeal to consumers. This is supported by the findings of Modi and Singh (2024), who noted that distinctive bottle designs and carefully selected colors trigger emotional reactions, merging utilitarian, emotional, and aesthetic factors.

The evolving nature of celebrity and influencer endorsements in the fragrance industry highlights their role as cultural sources of meaning. Participants emphasized the importance of authenticity and relatability, noting that overly commercial or low-quality content can lead to skepticism (Hudders et al., 2020; Rizomyliotis et al., 2019; Balaban et al., 2022). R19F, for instance, explained that her purchasing decision depends more on liking the scent itself than on the endorsement, reflecting a shift in cultural expectations and the dynamic role of advertising.

Social media amplifies the influence of celebrities and influencers, allowing them to shape trends and consumer perceptions while driving initial product discovery. Influencers who have gained credibility are widely recognized as "experts" in their domains (Schouten et al., 2019; AlFarraj et al., 2021) play a significant role in transferring cultural meanings and enhancing the impact of endorsements.

Effective advertising is a powerful tool for transferring cultural and product meanings to consumers, as observed in participants' comments on fragrance advertisements' emotional and artistic aspects. Perfume advertisements become vehicles for transferring cultural ideals, emotions, and lifestyle aspirations to the product, as noted by R5M, who highlighted the emphasis on artistic direction and emotional depth in the Burberry Touch ad. Designing advertisements that consider the cultural and personal values of customers would result in more effective marketing campaigns that can influence customer behavior and increase the likelihood of repeat purchase due to the satisfaction of their needs (Gupta & De, 2007).

5.1 Theoretical implications

This study extends McCracken's (1989) Meaning Transfer Model (MTM) by demonstrating its relevance to perfume advertising, where meanings must be translated into cultural symbols rather than communicated through direct sensory experience. The findings show how advertising encodes intangible qualities of scent through storytelling, semiotics, and music (Floch, 2002; Zelman, 1992; Korsgaard, 2013), confirming MTM's value for analyzing symbolic strategies unique to fragrance campaigns.

The research also adds details to endorsement literature by showing that while celebrities and influencers function as cultural carriers (Erdogan, 1999; Miller & Allen, 2012), their impact depends on sensory validation. This relationship between symbolic association and product experience refines understanding of meaning transfer in categories where consumer judgment cannot rest on symbolic cues alone.

Theoretically, the study extends beyond persuasion models such as the Elaboration Likelihood Model (Petty & Cacioppo, 1986), the Heuristic-Systematic Model (Chaiken, 1980), and the Source Credibility Model (Hovland & Weiss, 1951), which focus on message processing but do not account for the cultural circulation of meaning between endorsers, products, and consumers. By applying MTM to fragrance advertising, this research highlights the integration of sensory, emotional, and symbolic dimensions of consumer experience, extending the model's application to a

product category defined by intangibility and cultural symbolism. In doing so, the study strengthens understanding of how perfumes operate as cultural artifacts through which consumers negotiate self-expression and identity.

5.2 Managerial implications

The study offers several implications for fragrance companies seeking to strengthen consumer engagement. First, the findings indicate that celebrity and influencer endorsements play an important role in creating awareness and attaching symbolic associations to perfumes, but they do not by themselves secure purchase decisions. Consumers consistently emphasized the need to validate fragrances through direct sensory experience before committing to a purchase. For companies, this highlights the need to integrate aspirational storytelling with opportunities for trial, such as samples, in-store testing, and experiential campaigns that bridge symbolic promise with sensory confirmation.

Second, the research shows that consumers make perfume choices through a multi-channel process that combines digital discovery, peer influence, and physical testing. Social media and influencer content are important entry points, but credibility is reinforced by personal networks and hands-on experience. This emphasizes the importance of omnichannel strategies that connect online cultural narratives with offline experiences, ensuring continuity between symbolic advertising messages and consumers' embodied evaluations of scent.

Third, packaging emerged as more than a functional or aesthetic concern. Participants equated distinctive designs with quality and desirability, confirming that packaging acts as a cultural signal that conveys symbolic meaning alongside brand identity. Brands should therefore approach packaging design not only as a branding element but also as a storytelling medium that encodes cultural aspirations and reinforces the emotional positioning of the fragrance.

These implications suggest that perfume advertising is most effective when symbolic communication, sensory validation, and cultural signaling are aligned. Integration of these dimensions enables companies to reinforce consumer–brand identification and position perfumes as lifestyle expressions that link cultural symbolism with everyday use.

6 Conclusion

This study examines how perfume advertising captivates consumers by evoking cultural meanings through sensory, social, and emotional connections. Using McCracken's Meaning Transfer Model (MTM), the findings show how symbolic meanings embedded in advertisements influence consumer self-perception and identity. By connecting sensory-rich imagery, aspirational narratives, and endorsements with personal values, perfume advertisements play an important role in shaping consumer behavior and cultural aspirations.

The findings demonstrate that advertising carries cultural meaning that shapes societal norms and individual self-expression. By bridging the intangible qualities of

scent with symbolic narratives, perfume advertisements create meaningful consumer experiences that extend beyond the functional aspects of the product.

This research is not without limitations. The qualitative data, derived from a limited sample size, may not fully capture the diversity of consumer experiences across cultural or socioeconomic groups. Additionally, the findings are context-specific and may not generalize to other product categories or advertising contexts. Future research should address these limitations by incorporating larger and more diverse samples to explore how cultural, demographic, and geographic factors shape the meaning transfer process. Quantitative methods could complement these insights, providing statistical validation of observed trends.

7 Appendix

Interview Guide.
Introduction (5 min)

- **Interviewer Introduction**: Introduce yourself and explain the purpose of the study. example• *"Thank you for participating in this study. We're exploring how perfumes are marketed through advertisements*, *especially using celebrities and influencers. Our goal is to understand how these advertisements convey cultural and personal meanings*, *and how they influence consumer perceptions and identity. Your insights will contribute to research on the connections between advertising*, *cultural symbolism*, *and consumer behavior."*
- **Confidentiality Assurance**:
  - **Privacy of Responses**: All responses shared during the interview will remain confidential and will be used solely for research purposes. They will not be disclosed to any unauthorized individuals or third parties.
  - **Use of Quotations**: Direct quotations from participants may be used in the research report or publications but will be anonymized unless explicit consent has been obtained to attribute the quote to the participant.
  - **Anonymity of Participants**: Your identity will not be revealed in any reports, publications, or presentations unless you have explicitly provided consent to be identified.
- **Permission to Record**: Ask for consent to record the interview for transcription purposes.
- **Ice-Breaker Question**: *"Can you share a bit about your experience with perfumes or colognes?"*

Brand Awareness (10 min)

- *"When I mention male colognes/aftershave*, *what are the brand/label names that first come to your mind?"*

- *"When I mention female perfumes, what are the brand/label names that first come to your mind?"*
- **Follow-Up Probes**:
  - *"Why do these brands come to mind?"*
  - *"Are there any particular ads or associations you recall with these brands?"*

Personal Habits and Preferences (10 min)

- *"Why do you wear perfume/cologne?"*
- *"How do you feel when wearing perfume/cologne?"*
- *"How many different brands of perfume/cologne do you use?"*
- **Probing Questions**:
  - *"Do you associate specific perfumes with particular occasions?"*
  - *"What are your favorite types of scents (e.g., floral, citrus, fresh), and why?"*
- **Projective Techniques**:
  - Facilitate discussions about the feelings or emotions evoked by wearing a particular perfume.
  - Ask if they could assign a color to their favorite scent, what color would it be and why.

Information Sources and Purchase Behavior (10 min)

- *"Where do you get information regarding perfume/cologne?"*
- *"Which factors such as image, smell, packaging, shape, price, color, or others, do you consider when buying perfume/cologne?"*
- *"On average, how much money do you spend on buying fragrances?"*

Celebrity Endorsements and Advertising (15 min)

- *"Do you think celebrity endorsement helps to promote different perfumes/colognes?"*
- *"If yes, why and how do you think celebrities help to promote perfumes/colognes?"*
- *"What is your favorite perfume advertisement and why?"*
- **Probing Questions**:
  - *"Do you see celebrities as role models, and does that affect your perception of the product they endorse?"*
  - *"Do advertisements with celebrities create an emotional connection for you?"*
  - *"Are there any instances where a celebrity endorsement influenced your purchase decision?"*

- **Projective Techniques**:
  - Ask participants what emotions do they think the celebrities in perfume ads are trying to evoke, and how do they relate to them.

Wrap-Up (5 min)

- **Closing Question**: *"Is there anything else you'd like to share about your experience with perfume advertisements or celebrity endorsements?"*
- **Express Gratitude**: Thank the participant for their time and insights.
- **Next Steps**: Briefly explain how their responses will contribute to the study.

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Data availability The data that support the findings of this study are available upon request.

Declarations

Conflict of interest The author declares no conflicts of interest to disclose.

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